

Setting Up Your Avalanche Center Website

Your site is prepared and ready to install. This guide walks you through it from start to finish — no coding or technical background required. It takes about 10–15 minutes.

Before you begin, you'll need two things (whoever sent you this guide can provide them):

- **Your site's web address** — the URL where the setup wizard is waiting, e.g. `https://your-site.example.com`.
- The go-ahead to **create the main administrator account** (you'll do this in Step 3).

Fill this in for your reference —

My site address: _____

1 Open the installer and choose a language

Open your site's web address in a normal web browser (Chrome, Firefox, Safari, or Edge). The first time the site is visited, it shows a setup wizard. The first screen is **Choose language**.



Pick English here — even if you want a Spanish website. This screen only sets the language of the *setup wizard itself*. You'll choose your **site's** language a couple of steps from now (Step 4), and that's what actually makes the finished website Spanish.

Choosing Spanish on this first screen isn't harmful, but it can show a couple of harmless technical warnings — so English is the smooth path.

Click **Save and continue**.

2 Choose the installation profile

If you're asked which profile to install, choose **Avalanche Center**, then continue. (If the wizard skips straight ahead, that's fine — it was already selected for you.)

The installer will churn for a minute or two while it builds the site. Let it finish.

3 Configure the site and create your account

This is the standard site-configuration screen. You'll enter:

- A **site name** (your center's name — you can confirm or change it in the next step).
- The **administrator account**: a username, email address, and password.
- Site email / time zone settings (the defaults are usually fine).



The administrator account is the main login for your whole site — keep it somewhere safe. If the screen ever asks for *database details*, don't guess: the person who set up the site has those, and most setups fill this in automatically so you won't see it at all.

Click to continue and you'll land on the one screen that's specific to avalanche centers.

4 The “Center setup” screen

This is where you make the site yours. Here's what each field does:

Field	What it does
Avalanche center name	Becomes your site name and appears in page titles. It's pre-filled from Step 3 — leave it or edit it.
Logo (optional)	Upload your center's logo (PNG, JPG, GIF, or SVG). Leave it empty to use the built-in default; you can add or change it any time later.
Language	English or Spanish . Choosing Spanish makes the entire site — menus, danger scale, help pages, and starter content — come out in Spanish, and automatically pairs it with the South American danger scale.
Danger-scale preset	NAC (North American) or SAC (South American). Sets the colors, wording, and danger-scale page used on your forecasts. It follows your language choice by default (English → NAC, Spanish → SAC), but you can pick either one.
Map center (lat / long / zoom)	Where your avalanche danger map is centered. Put the latitude and longitude in their own separate boxes .
Weather service (optional)	The name and link of your local weather office, shown in the site header/footer.
Social media (optional)	Facebook, Twitter/X, YouTube, Instagram, and email-signup links, shown wherever the site displays social links.

Click **Save and continue**.

What this creates for you: a starter setup so the site isn't empty — one sample forecast zone, one sample advisory (which the front page points at so the danger map has something to show), and three ready-made reference pages linked in the menu:

- **How to Read the Avalanche Forecast**
- **The Avalanche Danger Scale** (North or South American, matching your choice)
- **Avalanche Problems**

On a Spanish site these all appear in Spanish. Keep and edit the reference pages; replace the sample advisory and zone with your own real content (see below).

You're live! 🎉

The website is now installed and running at your address. Log in any time at `your-site-address/user` with the administrator account you created in Step 3.

Making it your own

Once you're logged in, here's how to turn the starter site into your real one. Everything below is done by clicking around the admin area — no code.

Replace the sample content

Under **Content**, delete the “Demo Avalanche Advisory” and its “Demo Forecast Zone” once you've created your real ones (below) — otherwise visitors land on the sample.

Add your forecast zones

Go to **Structure** → **Taxonomy** → **Forecast Region**. Each zone is an entry there, with a map tool to draw that zone's boundary (or paste boundary data if you already have it). Your advisories will point at one of these zones.

Publish your first advisory

Go to **Content** → **Add content** → **Advisory**. This is the forecast itself — danger ratings by elevation, the bottom-line summary, and which forecast zone it's for. This is what the danger map and front page display.

Set your home page

The danger map appears on the front page. To make a real advisory (or something else) your home page instead of the sample, go to **Configuration** → **System** → **Basic site settings** → **Front page**.

Adjust your branding and theme

Under **Appearance** you can switch between the two included designs and open a theme's **Settings** to change the logo, name/slogan, weather-service info, social links, and elevation-band labels. Your Step 4 choices are already filled in here.

Edit the avalanche glossary

The glossary lives at `your-site-address/avalanche-terms` and is managed under **Structure** → **Taxonomy** → **Avalanche Terms**.

Give your staff access

Under **People**, create accounts for your forecasters and assign them the **Editor** role — that lets them publish advisories and content without full administrator control.

Moving to your own server later

If you're using a shared demo now, it's a great place to build out your real content. When you're ready to run the site on your own hosting, **you don't have to start over** — your content and setup can come with you. The site has two built-in exporters for exactly this, both in the admin area:

- **Your content** — advisories, forecast zones, glossary, and user accounts. Go to **Configuration** → **Development** → **Backup and Migrate**, create a backup, and **download** the file. (It's a snapshot of your whole database.)
- **Your structure and settings** — content types, fields, your danger-scale choice, branding. Go to **Configuration** → **Development** → **Configuration management** → **Export** and download that archive too.

Then, on your new site:

1. Have whoever sets up your new hosting install the **Avalanche Center** distribution first — the same one you installed here (point them at the project's `README`).
2. Give them the two files you downloaded. They'll restore the Backup and Migrate file, import the configuration archive, and copy over any images you uploaded.

Your new site then comes up with your zones, advisories, glossary, and branding intact.



Note for your developer / host. Backdrop keeps *content* in the database and *structure* in `files/config_<hash>/active`, where `<hash>` is `md5(serialize($database))` — it changes with the new database credentials, so place the imported config into the new hash directory (or pin `$config_directories` explicitly in `settings.php`). The new server's `settings.php` also needs `$settings['backdrop_drupal_compatibility'] = TRUE;`, and uploaded files live under `files/`.

Getting help. If anything looks off or you get stuck, reply to the email that sent you this guide and include the site address and a screenshot — that's the fastest way to get it sorted.